

Bylaws of the Michigan Outdoor Writers Association

Adopted as “Constitution and Bylaws” at the Organizational Meeting of the Michigan Outdoor Writers Association at Blaney Park, Mich., Jan. 14-16, 1944 and amended in 1966, 1971, 1994, 1996, 2002 2004, 2008, 2009, 2015, 2016; amended and combined into a single document at the 75th Anniversary Meeting at Thompsonville, Mich., May 30-June 2, 2019; April 13, 2021; April 12, 2025, June 12, 2026

SECTION 1 — NAME

The name of this organization shall be the Michigan Outdoor Writers Association.

SECTION 2 — DECLARATION OF PURPOSE AND PRINCIPLES

The Michigan Outdoor Writers Association is the state-level organization for professionals who communicate about outdoors topics and issues. Its members strive to achieve three goals:

- To support and encourage one another in the development of their communication skills, professional standards, and market opportunities
- To engage in a professional/social network of like-minded individuals
- To establish and maintain ties to the community through several public outreach programs

The concept of “freedom of expression” must be the cornerstone of any group engaged in journalism, and the Association holds it in the highest regard. It neither restricts nor endorses members in their choices of topics or the stands they take in their published work.

SECTION 3 — STATUS

The association shall be structured as a 509 (A) (2) organization.

SECTION 4 — MEMBERSHIP

4.01: Voting Members, Rights

The core membership of the Michigan Outdoor Writers Association shall comprise the Active, Senior-Active, and Retired categories. Only these members are eligible to participate in business meetings, vote, and hold office. These voting members shall determine appropriate guidelines for all classes of membership.

4.02 Recommending New Members

Only voting members may recommend applicants for all classes of membership to the Membership Committee. Upon approval, the committee shall distribute the names and qualifications of such applicants to both the board and the voting members. After stipulating a comment period for members, the board shall take action on each application. At any regular meeting, a majority of voting members may veto a decision of the board of directors to accept or reject any applicant in any category.

4.03 Voting Membership Qualifications

Active

- Must be a resident of Michigan at the time of application
- Must produce outdoor communication (writing, broadcast, graphic art, photography, etc.) for public consumption for pay and on a regular basis. Contributions to club or private newsletters do not qualify.
- Must provide evidence of having produced outdoor communication for pay for a minimum of one year

Senior-Active

- Currently hold Active membership status in MOWA
- Have reached the age of 65
- Have belonged to MOWA for at least 10 years

Retired

- Must meet Senior-Active requirements
- Must no longer produce outdoor communications for pay

4.04 Retirement Status

Active members who wish to claim Senior-Active or Retired status may do so by submitting a written statement of that intent to the president. The president shall disseminate the information to the secretary, treasurer, and chairman of the Membership Committee.

4.05 Non-Voting Membership Qualifications

Apprentice

- Must be an adult (18+ YOA) Michigan resident interested in or pursuing a course of action that would lead to a career in or an avocation as a communicator of the outdoors experience, i.e. outdoor recreation, natural resources, the environment, etc.
- Dues-paying member
- Non-voting but eligible to participate in all activities, including EIC contests for paid work
- Three-year limit for membership in this category with one exception, noted next
- MOWA's "Fresh Voices for the Outdoors" Award winners are eligible for dues-free Apprentice membership for a period of five years; non-winning entrants, three.

Supporting

- An outdoor industry professional representing an entity that creates products, materials, or intellectual properties, or offers services relating to outdoors recreation or natural resources
–OR–
- A representative of an agency, institution, non-profit organization, conservation group, convention bureau, or other such group that generates news about the outdoors or which offers assistance in gathering such news
- Individual eligibility will be determined by the MOWA Board of Directors

4.06 Non-voting Member – Retaining Eligibility

Non-voting members maintain their status as long as they meet the qualifying standards and/or represent a qualifying entity. If/When they leave such an entity they are no longer eligible for membership. Additionally, they are not eligible to claim Retired Member status.

SECTION 5 — ANNUAL DUES

5.01 Establishment of Dues

Annual dues for all classes of membership shall be proposed by the board and determined by the majority of voting members.

5.02 Reduced Dues

The group may establish reduced annual dues for Retired and Senior Active members.

5.03 Non-payment of Dues

Annual dues are payable January 1. After June 1, members whose dues remain unpaid will be considered withdrawn. If at a later date they desire to rejoin the group, they may request the President or the Chair of the Membership Committee for reinstatement. Such requests will be presented to the board for further action.

SECTION 6 — GOVERNMENT OF THE ASSOCIATION

6.01 Governing Officers

The association shall be governed by such officers and a board of three directors as named in this section. The officers shall be the chairman of the board, president, vice president, secretary, and treasurer.

6.02 Officer Compensation

Officers to serve without compensation except treasurer and secretary, who may be compensated if so determined by the board and approved by the membership.

6.03 Board Responsibilities and Authority

The board of directors shall act upon such matters as may be brought to its attention by the presiding officer. The board shall have the authority to conduct all routine and such emergency matters as may arise.

SECTION 7 — ELECTION OF OFFICERS

7.01 Election Schedule, Conditions

All officers shall be elected by the voting members of the association prior to or at the annual business meeting, provided that the immediate past president shall automatically become chairman of the board of directors and the immediate past vice president shall become president.

7.02 Staggered Board Elections

Each year, one director shall be elected to a three-year term.

7.03 Nominations Committee

Prior to such elections, a nominating committee shall present the membership a ballot of proposed officers and directors. Voting members will have the opportunity to make additional nominations before the election is held.

7.04 Vacancies

Vacancies on the board of directors or in any office between business meetings shall be filled by the board of directors.

SECTION 8 — DUTIES OF THE OFFICERS

8.01 President, vice president

The president and vice president shall perform such duties as usually fall upon the incumbents of such offices.

8.02 Secretary

The secretary shall perform such duties as usually fall upon the holder of that office, such as keeping the minutes of all meetings and attending to such correspondence as may be directed by the president. He/she shall send a copy of the minutes of all board and membership meetings to the members of the association within a reasonable time of the holding of such meetings.

8.03 Treasurer

The treasurer shall collect monies due the association, shall hold such funds and distribute same at the direction of the authorized officer or officers of the association. He/she shall make an annual report of receipts and disbursements to the board of directors.

8.04 Chairman of the Board

The chairman of the board shall perform such duties as usually fall upon the incumbent of such office: advise the officers and board upon request, chair board meetings, and cast tie-breaking votes at board meetings.

SECTION 9 — DUTIES OF THE BOARD OF DIRECTORS

9.01 Duties

The board of directors shall take action upon all matters as are brought to its attention by the president and as delegated to it by formal action of the membership.

9.02 Board and officer Meetings

The officers and board shall meet at least once a year.

9.03 Resignation or Removal of Officers or Directors

Any officers or directors may resign at any time by notifying the president or the secretary of their intentions. The resignation shall take effect at the time specified in writing.

Any officer or director may be removed from office, with or without cause, by a two-third majority vote of the board (officers plus directors).

Any officer or director absent from three (3) meetings in a twelve (12)-month period is automatically terminated and shall be so notified in writing by the president and the vacant seat filled by the board.

SECTION 10 — MEETINGS OF MEMBERS

10.01 Annual Meeting

The annual business meeting of the membership shall be held as part of the annual conference at such time, place, and date as designated by the president with the support of the majority of the board.

10.02 Order of Business

- Reading of the minutes of last meeting
- Report of the Secretary
- Report of the Treasurer
- Report of the President
- Reports of the Committees
- Unfinished or Old Business
- New Business
- Adjournment

10.03 Minimum Duration of Annual Meeting

Once the annual business meeting has been called to order, no adjournment may be taken until the point of unfinished business has been reached, except by a two-thirds vote of those present.

10.04 Adjustments to Order of Business

The order of business may be adjusted by the president.

10.05 Additional Meetings

At any such meeting of the association, a majority present may elect to hold extra meetings of the membership without restriction of character.

Section 11 — Quorums

11.01 Annual Meeting

The quorum of any annual meeting or meeting of the entire membership shall be a majority of the members present.

11.02 Board/Officer Meetings

A quorum of four officers and board members is established for meetings or for a vote.

11.03 Board/Officers – Minimum for Transacting Business

The board of directors may transact routine or emergency business for the association through agreement of any four of its members of which the president must be one.

SECTION 12: STANDING COMMITTEES

All standing committees of the association shall consist of three to five members and be appointed by the president following each annual meeting of the association.

SECTION 13 — SPECIAL COMMITTEES

The president may name such special committees as he/she deems necessary at any meeting and at any time.

SECTION 14 — OFFICIAL ORGAN

An official organ of the association may be published at such times and in such forms as may be determined by the board of directors of the association.

SECTION 15 — DIRECTORY

15.01 Approved Use

The association's directory is made available for official and individual member use only. No member shall transfer the directory or any part of its contents to any non-member individual, company, or agency. Individual referrals (such as recommending a communicator to an editor or publisher) are excepted.

15.02 Penalty

A member who provides a non-member access to the directory or the information contained therein — by any means or in any format — will be assessed up to one year's Supporting member's dues, at the discretion of the board.

Failure to pay the assessment will cause the member's dues to fall into arrears, per Section 5.03 of these bylaws.

15.03 Non-member Access

A non-member requesting a copy of the directory may purchase a one-time use for the cost of one year's Supporting member's dues.

SECTION 16 — LOGO

16.01 Approved Use

The only acceptable uses of the association's logo are to indicate membership and for association business.

16.02 Penalty

Any member who supplies the logo or permits its use for other purposes, such as to imply MOWA's endorsement of an outside activity or business enterprise, or to suggest a non-existent relationship between the group and a third party, agrees to the assessment conditions outlined in Section 15.02 above.

SECTION 17 — PARLIAMENTARY PROCEDURE

All questions of parliamentary procedure not covered by these bylaws and the constitution of this association shall be governed by the procedure laid down in *Robert's Rules of Order*.

SECTION 18 — DISSOLUTION

18.01 Procedure

In event of the dissolution of the Michigan Outdoor Writers Association, all assets, real and personal, shall be disposed of by the board of directors.

Disposal of assets shall be for purposes that are in keeping with the goals and tenets of MOWA.

18.02 Individual Benefits

No member shall profit from such disposal.

SECTION 19 — AMENDMENTS TO THE BYLAWS

Amendments to these bylaws may be made at the annual meeting by a majority of the membership of the association or by a vote of the membership upon order of the president, but only after the membership of the association shall have been notified of such changes two weeks in advance of such action.